

Multicultural Competence Reflective Summary

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When I began my multicultural counseling coursework, I believed that being respectful and open-minded was enough to work effectively with people from different backgrounds. My assignments challenged that belief by showing me that cultural competence requires active self-reflection and a willingness to feel uncomfortable. The Implicit Association Tests brought unconscious beliefs about race, weight, gender, and careers to my attention, including ideas shaped by my family and the community in which I grew up. My first reaction was discomfort and disappointment, but I learned that acknowledging a bias is not the same as allowing it to define my character. It gives me the responsibility to examine where it came from, notice how it could affect a client, and take intentional steps to keep learning.

My multicultural immersion experience made this learning more personal. Spending time with a Malaysian Muslim family allowed me to listen to their experiences with immigration, faith, stigma, access to counseling, and fears of being misunderstood. I also had to correct assumptions I had made about ethnicity and religion. Being welcomed into their home, sharing food and conversation, and participating in henna after being invited reminded me that cultural learning should be relational, respectful, and guided by the people whose culture is being shared. My work on decolonizing research expanded this understanding by showing how Western systems have dismissed Indigenous knowledge and conducted research without consent. I learned that counseling and research can cause harm when professionals treat their own worldview as the standard.

Across these experiences, I have grown from wanting to be culturally competent to understanding cultural humility as an ongoing practice. I now pay closer attention to a client's language, history, beliefs, family relationships, community, and experiences with systems of power. I know that people who share a culture or religion are not all the same, and I cannot replace curiosity with assumptions. As a future counselor, I want to ask meaningful questions, seek supervision, recognize cultural strengths, and create a space where clients do not have to defend or translate every part of who they are. I will continue examining my biases and learning directly from communities. This coursework has made me more accountable, more curious, and better prepared to listen to understand rather than assuming that respect alone is enough.